

Chicago Tribune



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THURSDAY, APRIL 17, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

EMIL JONES III TRIAL

Jones blasts FBI mole, ex-colleague

Legislator calls red-light camera executive ‘used car salesman,’ Sandoval a ‘bully’ as testimony continues

By Jason Meisner and Caroline Kubzansky
Chicago Tribune

State Sen. Emil Jones III told a federal jury Wednesday that a red-light camera company executive who was wining and dining him in the summer of 2019 reminded him of “a used car salesman” and that he never asked him directly for any money, only possible support for a fundraiser.

Testifying in his own defense in his brib-

ery trial, Jones also had critical words for his now-deceased colleague, former state Sen. Martin Sandoval, describing the once-powerful head of the Senate Transportation Committee as “kind of a bully.”

As a sitting elected official, Jones is taking a considerable risk by testifying, exposing himself to potential allegations of perjury that could lead to an enhanced sentence if he’s convicted.

But Jones is the only one who can put a different spin on statements he made on

undercover recordings made by SafeSpeed LLC co-founder Omar Maani, who was working as an FBI mole. It’s also an opportunity for Jones to try to lay a significant amount of blame at the feet of Sandoval, who pleaded guilty in the same sweeping red-light camera probe and was cooperating with investigators at the time of his death from COVID-19 complications in December 2020.

In the undercover videos shown to the jury, Sandoval introduced Maani to Jones over a steak dinner and told him Maani wanted to be his “friend.” In a later dinner, Maani talked with Jones alone about raising \$5,000 for the senator’s campaign and hiring

Jones’ onetime intern, Christopher Katz, for a \$15-an-hour part-time job at SafeSpeed.

Over about five hours of direct examination beginning Tuesday, Jones has been poised and calm on the stand, testifying in a deep clear voice despite suffering from a bit of congestion. He told relatives during a break he’d taken cold medicine and was on lozenges to help his throat.

U.S. District Judge Andrea Wood recessed the trial for the day with Jones still on direct examination. He’s expected to wrap up his testimony Thursday, including what promises to be a lengthy cross-examination.

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JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

CHERRY BLOSSOM SHOW RETURNS

Nafisa Cassim, left, of California, and Amatullah Dahodwala, of Chicago, photograph cherry blossoms near the Columbia Basin in Jackson Park on Tuesday. According to the Chicago Park District, 20 new cherry blossom trees have been planted at Jackson Park since the last full bloom in 2020. This year’s full bloom is expected to happen by the end of April. Cherry blossoms’ full bloom is short-lived, lasting just three to five days, depending on the weather.

Plan seeks to give police OK to set curfews

Alderman’s proposal would allow them on as-needed basis

By Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

A downtown alderman introduced a proposal Wednesday he said he has been negotiating with Mayor Brandon Johnson’s administration that would give police officials power to declare temporary curfews for unaccompanied minors anywhere in the city on an as-needed basis.

Ald. Brian Hopkins, 2nd, texted some of his colleagues Wednesday morning that he would no longer try to force a City Council vote on an 8 p.m. curfew downtown after a series of so-called “teen takeover” gatherings ended in violence in his ward.

His decision averted what was expected to be a council showdown over how to address chaotic gatherings during the summer.

Instead, Hopkins introduced new legislation he said he has been discussing with



Ald. Brian Hopkins, 2nd, stands before a City Council meeting Wednesday at City Hall.
BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

police Superintendent Larry Snelling’s team to grant Chicago police brass the authority to announce a curfew for minors in order to give them 30 minutes to disperse from a particular location.

“I’ve been working with the superintendent’s office (he prefers to stay on background, for obvious reasons) to come up with a substitute, and now we have a good

one,” Hopkins wrote in the text.

Johnson had taken a dim view in recent weeks of Hopkins’ proposed downtown-only early curfew for minors. Asked Wednesday about whether he backs the alderman’s revised proposal for spot curfews at the discretion of police, the

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Judge finds probable cause for contempt

Says administration violated directive to return deportees

By Alanna Durkin Richer and Michael Kunzelman
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — A federal judge on Wednesday said he has found probable cause to hold the Trump administration in criminal contempt of court for violating his orders last month to turn around planes carrying deportees to an El Salvador prison.

The ruling from U.S. District Judge James Boasberg, whom President Donald Trump has said should be impeached, marks a dramatic battle between the judicial and executive branches of government over the president’s powers to carry out key White House priorities.

Boasberg accused administration officials of rushing deportees out of the

Turn to Contempt, Page 4

Bulls’ brand still in good shape

Bulls fans still turning out “through thick and thin.” Now, about that TV deal ... **Paul Sullivan in Chicago Sports**

Powell: Tariffs will raise inflation

Federal Reserve chair says higher prices, slower growth likely, which may create “challenging scenario.” **Business**

Trump in active trade-talks role

President inserts himself directly into talks with Japanese officials in Washington. **Nation & World**

TODAY’S WEATHER



High 65 Low 57

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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